

نَسْمَة

Everyday Shami

Small Conversations, Real
Life

Practical Levantine Arabic
from study notes and everyday stories.

Jacob Shore

Selected pages from the full book

WELCOME TO THE SAMPLE

A little Shami you can use today

Learn how to keep a conversation going—even when a word goes missing.

This sample gives you a complete lesson to try, with Arabic, pronunciation support, practice, and answers. You do not need to read Arabic script to get started.

Try it in three steps

1. Read the study method and pronunciation key on pages 3–6.
2. Learn the eight conversation phrases on pages 7–8, then try the practice on page 9 before checking page 10.
3. Explore the texting examples, illustrated reading, and idioms on pages 11–15.

Make one phrase yours

Choose a situation you have actually been in. Close the page, say what you would need in Arabic, and check your attempt. Return to the same situation tomorrow.

These selections come from *Everyday Shami: Small Conversations, Real Life* by Jacob Shore. The sample follows its own page numbering.

STUDY METHODS & MEMORY · FROM MY EXPERIENCE

Start with flashcards

A flashcard has a prompt on one side and an answer on the other. The prompt might be an English meaning, a situation, an Arabic word, a picture, or a recording. You try to recall the answer before turning the card over or revealing it on screen.

What a review looks like

Front: You want a coffee. How would you say that in Arabic?

Back: بدي قهوة. (biddi 'ahwe) – “I want a coffee.” Keep the pronunciation beside the Arabic, and add a reliable audio example if you have one.

Say your answer before revealing the back. Then compare it with the model. If you could not remember it, read and say the answer, then return to the card later. Simply recognizing the answer after you reveal it is different from recalling it yourself.

Where Anki fits

I use Anki, a digital flashcard app, to organize my cards and schedule reviews. That is my setup; you can use another app or paper cards. When I say “cards” in the study advice, I mean these flashcards.

I make cards from language I have already encountered and understood. The card gives me another chance to retrieve it; it does not replace learning what it means or hearing how it is pronounced. The following pages show how I use them, including a more detailed worked card.

STUDY METHODS & MEMORY · FROM MY EXPERIENCE

Give the card a job

My preferred cards combine Arabic script, sound, pronunciation support, and an image or meaningful context. The script helps me see patterns; sound gives me something to imitate. Transliteration is a helper. I also find emojis helpful for memory. A small cue can bring back the meaning or situation when I review.

I use Anki mainly to maintain things I have already met. A card should remind me of language I understand. If I do not understand the sentence, I need to learn or clarify it before treating repeated exposure to the card as progress.

A worked card from chapter 1

Front: You are speaking to a man. You heard the sentence but need him to repeat it. Ask him in Arabic.

Back: **ممكن تعيد؟** (*mumkin t'īd*) – “Could you repeat?” Add a checked audio example when available, and keep a note of where you heard it. The feminine listener form is **ممكن تعيدي** (*mumkin t'īdi*).

This is a proposed card built from the book. The situation asks you to produce the phrase; displaying the Arabic on the front would ask you to recognize it instead. Both are useful tasks, but they test different things.

Say it before revealing it

Try an answer aloud, then check. If you could understand the phrase but could not produce it, record that distinction honestly. Make a separate listening prompt when you have suitable audio: hear the phrase before seeing the script.

This edition has no embedded audio. A pronunciation line is not an audio recording, and my own recording is an attempt to get feedback on, not automatic evidence of the correct pronunciation.

BEFORE YOU LEARN YOUR FIRST WORDS

Don't guess the vowels

Knowing the Arabic letters is not the same as knowing how a word is pronounced. Most everyday Arabic is written without the diacritics that mark short vowels. You can recognize every letter and still be unsure which vowel sounds belong between them.

Native readers draw on a vast store of familiar words, grammar, conjugations, and context to supply those missing sounds. When you are starting, you do not yet have that knowledge to draw on. Reading the letters alone can leave you guessing.

Learn the sound with the word

At the beginning, use clear transliteration, a reliable audio example, or both alongside the Arabic and its meaning. Transliteration makes the intended vowels visible. Audio lets you hear the sounds, stress, and rhythm that Latin letters cannot fully convey. A tutor or speaker of the variety you are learning can also model the word for you.

The aim is to avoid practising a guess until it becomes a habit. You do not want your first words stored with a wrong or confusing pronunciation that you later have to untangle.

A useful first encounter

Read the meaning. Check the pronunciation support and listen if you have audio. Say the word, then use it in a short phrase. Keep the Arabic spelling beside it so that the written form and the sound become familiar together.

As your vocabulary and knowledge of Arabic patterns grow, you will be able to infer more from the script. Until then, pronunciation support is part of learning the word.

NO ARABIC ALPHABET REQUIRED

Start with one line

The bronze text beside an Arabic example tells you how to say it using Latin letters. Read it from left to right. Start with the meaning, say the phrase, then cover the example and try again.

بدي قهوة (biddi 'ahwe) – “I want a coffee.”

Read *biddi* as two beats, *bid-di*, holding the doubled *d* a little longer. In *'ahwe*, the *'* is a small catch in the throat and the final *e* is short. The spaces separate words; a hyphen inside a pronunciation line does not mean a pause.

A small key to keep nearby

ā, ī, ū: hold the vowel longer. Think “ah,” “ee,” and “oo,” keeping the sound steady.

ē, ō: long “eh” and “oh” sounds, without a strong English glide at the end.

sh: as in “ship.” **j:** as in “vision” in this book.

kh, gh: back-of-the-mouth sounds; *kh* resembles the sound in Scottish “loch,” while *gh* uses the voice.

': the catch in “uh-oh.” **‘**: a separate voiced throat sound; it is not an apostrophe to skip.

h: a breathy throat sound, different from ordinary *h*.

š, đ, ʈ, ʐ: the emphatic versions of *s, d, t, z*. The dot marks a sound distinction.

You can answer every exercise aloud or in transliteration. For the diary task, dictate or write your sentences in Latin letters if that lets you concentrate on expressing the idea. Return to the Arabic spelling as you learn it.

Use a reliable spoken example or tutor feedback to refine the sounds. This edition has no embedded audio; the lines cannot demonstrate stress or voice quality by themselves.

CHAPTER 01 · EVERYDAY SHAMI

Keep the conversation going

خَلِّينِي أَفْكَّر

khallīni afakker

Ask for help, buy thinking time, and recover when you lose a word.

A conversation does not end when you miss a word. Often you only need to point to the gap: you did not hear, you did not understand, or you understood but cannot reply yet. Those are different problems, and Shami gives you short ways to name each one. Learn these expressions early. They let you keep using Arabic while you are still learning it.

أَنَا لَسَا بَتَعَلِّمُ عَرَبِي.

ana lissa bat'allam 'arabi.

I'm still learning Arabic.

مَا فَهَمْتُ.

ma fhimt.

I didn't understand.

مَمْكِن تَعِيدُ؟

mumkin t'īd?

Could you repeat? (to a man)

مَمْكِن تَعِيدِي؟

mumkin t'īdi?

Could you repeat? (to a woman)

شُو يَعْنِي ...؟

shū ya'ni ...?

What does ... mean?

خَلِّينِي أَفْكَّر.

khallīni afakker.

Let me think.

نَسِيتِ الْكَلِمَةَ.

nsīt il-kilme.

I forgot the word.

أَه، هَلَا فَهَمْتُ.

āh, halla' fhimt.

Ah, now I understand.

NOTICE THE PATTERN

Choose the repair you actually need

If the sound went past too quickly, ask for repetition. If you heard the word but do not know its meaning, use **شو يعني ...؟** (*shū ya'ni ...?*). If the meaning is clear but your answer is not ready, use **خلّيني أفكر** (*khallīni afakker*). This keeps the other person from explaining the whole sentence again when you only need a moment.

You can narrow the problem further: **ما فهمت الكلمة هاي** (*ma fhimt il-kilme hāy*) means “I didn’t understand this word.” The order “the word + this” occurs naturally in Palestinian speech. Learn the whole expression before trying to build a rule for every possible position of “this.”

A request changes with the listener

In the pair **تعيد / تعيدي** (*tʿīd / tʿīdi*), the final *-i* marks the request addressed to a woman. Your own gender does not decide this ending. A woman speaking to a man uses **ممکن تعيد؟** (*mumkin tʿīd*); a man speaking to a woman uses **ممکن تعيدي؟** (*mumkin tʿīdi*).

For “slowly,” add **على مهلك** (*‘ala mahlak*) when addressing a man: **ممکن تعيد على مهلك؟** (*mumkin tʿīd ‘ala mahlak?*). With a woman, say **ممکن تعيدي على مهلك؟** (*mumkin tʿīdi ‘ala mahlik?*), pronouncing the final possessive ending in **مهلك** (*mahlak / mahlik*) as *-ik*. The ordinary unvowelled spelling can hide a spoken distinction.

A tiny exchange

أنا لسا بتعلّم عربي. — (ana lissa bat'allam 'arabi)

ولا يهّمك. — (wala yhimmak)

شو يعني «متأخّر»؟ — (shū ya'ni «mit'akhkher»?)

يعني مش بكير. — (ya'ni mish bakkīr)

آه، هلاً فهمت. — (āh, halla' fhimt)

“I’m still learning Arabic.” / “No worries.” / “What does ‘late’ mean?” / “It means not early.” / “Ah, now I understand.”

You do not need to memorize the exchange as a performance. Reuse its shape: announce your level, ask one precise question, and acknowledge the answer.

Make it yours

1. Ask a woman to repeat what she said.
2. You heard a word clearly but do not know its meaning. Which expression fits?
3. Translate: “I forgot the word. Let me think.”
4. Personal practice: choose one real word you recently forgot. Ask what it means, then say that you understand.

Answer aloud or in transliteration if you prefer. [Answers for chapter 1](#) →

Study it

Make a situation card: you did not understand a word. Hide the Arabic, make your request aloud, and then check it.

[Return to the method](#) →

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answers & models

These are possible answers, not the only natural ways to express the ideas. Personal tasks allow many responses.

01 • Keep the conversation going

1. ممكن تعيدي؟ (mumkin t'idi)
Could you repeat? (to a woman)
2. شو يعني ...؟ (shū ya'ni ...?) Put the unfamiliar word in the gap.
What does ... mean?
3. نسيت الكلمة. خليني أفكر. (nsīt il-kilme. khallīni afakker)
I forgot the word. Let me think.
4. One model: شو يعني «بكير»؟ آه، هلا فهمت. (shū ya'ni «bakkīr»? āh, halla' fhimt) "What does 'early' mean? Ah, now I understand." Your chosen word can differ.

One more try

Cover the answers and repeat the exchange aloud. Change the missing word to something from your own day.

TEXTING & TYPING · BEFORE CHAPTER 1

Text a little Arabic

Texting gives you time to reread and edit. Practise messages with a purpose: arranging a time, announcing your arrival, or asking for an address.

Suggest a time to meet

Text: *bukra el sa3a sitte?*

Arabic and pronunciation: بكرة الساعة ستة؟ (*bukra s-sā'a sitte?*)

Meaning: Tomorrow at six?

Let your friend know you are downstairs

Text: *wselet, ana ta7t.*

Arabic and pronunciation: وصلت، أنا تحت. (*wiṣilt, ana taḥt*)

Meaning: I've arrived. I'm downstairs.

Ask for the address before visiting

Text: *mumkin tib3atli el 3inwan?*

Arabic and pronunciation: ممكن تبعثلي العنوان؟ (*mumkin tib'at-li l-'inwān?*)

Meaning: Can you send me the address? (to a man)

Write something you would actually send

Choose a real situation: arrange a visit, send an arrival update, or ask for a detail you need. Draft a short message in Arabizi, check its meaning, and edit it. The aim is a useful message, not a fast reply.

These are teaching examples; texting spellings vary. Keep a translation in your study note and add an Arabic explanation when helpful. The next page shows how I turn Latin-letter input into Arabic script.

READING 1 · PICTURE THE SITUATION

A missing drink



Original Daily Derja illustration for When Delivery Disappoints.

لسا عطشان (lissa 'aṭshān) – still thirsty. The illustration gives a visual cue for the state that remains after the delivery arrives.

Continue with the Arabic reading →

READ IN CONTEXT

Reading 1 · When Delivery Disappoints

اليوم طلبت أكل ومشروب من مطعم.

لما وصلني التوصيل، ما كان في مشروب مع الطلب.
والأكل كان عادي، مش زكي كثير. عندي أكل بالدار
أطيب منه.

لما انتبهت، كان تبع التوصيل راح.

أنا متضايق كثير ولسا عطشان، وبفكر إني ما أطلب
من هالمطعم مرة تانية.

Today I ordered food and a drink from a restaurant. When the delivery arrived, there was no drink with the order. The food was ordinary—not very tasty. I have food at home that is tastier than it. By the time I noticed, the delivery person had gone. I’m very annoyed and still thirsty, and I’m thinking of not ordering from this restaurant again.

Notice how **لسا** (*lissa*) connects the missing drink to the writer’s present state. **لما** (*lamma*) moves the story through arrival and discovery. **كان ... راح** (*kān ... rāḥ*) places the delivery person’s departure before the moment of noticing. The passage gives you an event, a consequence, and a possible future decision.

Source: “When Delivery Disappoints,” selected body text, 1 October 2026. [Read the original.](#)

[Full transliteration and English →](#)

READ IN CONTEXT · PRONUNCIATION COMPANION

Say it aloud

Reading 1 · When Delivery Disappoints. Read left to right; the paragraph order matches the Arabic.

il-yōm ṭalabt akil w mashrūb min maṭ'am.

lamma wiṣilni t-tawṣīl, ma kān fī mashrūb ma' iṭ-ṭalab. w il-akil kān 'ādi, mish zāki ktīr. 'indi akil bid-dār aṭyab minno.

lamma intabaht, kān taba' it-tawṣīl rāḥ.

ana mitḍāye' ktīr w lissa 'aṭshān, w bafakker inni ma aṭlob min hal-maṭ'am marra tānye.

Meaning

Today I ordered food and a drink from a restaurant. When the delivery arrived, there was no drink with the order. The food was ordinary—not very tasty. I have food at home that is tastier than it. By the time I noticed, the delivery person had gone. I'm very annoyed and still thirsty, and I'm thinking of not ordering from this restaurant again.

← Arabic text and explanation

A TASTE OF THE REFERENCE

More than the literal meaning

Learn the situation an expression belongs to, alongside its words.

على راسي

‘ala rāsi

Gladly; of course. Literally, “on my head.” A respectful way to agree to a request.

ولا يهّمك

wala yhimmak

Don’t worry about it. Literally, “don’t let it concern you.” Reassure someone that you will take care of it.

صحتين

ṣaḥṭēn

Enjoy your food. Literally, “two healths.” An expression to use around a meal.

يسلموا إيديك

yislamu idēk

Thank you for making this. Literally, “may your hands be kept safe.” Thank someone for cooking, making, or fixing something.

KEEP LEARNING

Take the next conversation further

The full book builds from small exchanges to telling stories, describing feelings, and writing about your own life.

Inside the full book

- Study and memory methods drawn from my own learning.
- Everyday language lessons, practice tasks, and model answers.
- Readings with English translations and pronunciation companions.
- Arabizi and the typing tools I use.
- A substantial reference of expressions, idioms, themed vocabulary, and phrases, plus alphabetical lookup.

More from Daily Derja

Visit dailyderja.com for more Arabic readings and learning material.

Everyday Shami · Small Conversations, Real Life
Jacob Shore